The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: EPA

Ukraine and **Russia** ended their second day of American-led peace negotiations in Geneva after just two hours. The White House said that “meaningful progress” had been made and suggested there would be more talks soon. But Volodymyr Zelensky called the discussions “difficult”. Ukraine’s president accused Russia of dragging out negotiations instead of moving towards an agreement to end the four-year war.

Mark Zuckerberg defended Meta’s handling of child safety while testifying in a trial about his company’s effects on young users’ mental health. The case is the first of more than 1,600 lawsuits alleging that social-media platforms were designed to be addictive. Meta denies wrongdoing. A ruling against it could mean tech firms lose protections that have shielded them from legal liability.

Friedrich Merz, Germany’s chancellor, indicated he would back controls on children’s access to social media. His Christian Democratic Union party is set to debate such proposals on Friday. Meanwhile **Emmanuel Macron**, France’s president, said that though social-media firms “claim to be in favour of free speech”, he thinks that this defence is “pure bullshit if nobody knows how you are guided” to such speech.

Spain's economic ministry said it would strive to secure an "influential" position on the **European Central Bank's** executive board. The *Financial Times* reported that the ECB's head, Christine Lagarde, may depart before her term ends in October 2027 so that France's president, Emmanuel Macron, is still in office to help pick her successor. Pablo Hernández de Cos, Spain's former central-bank governor, is a possible contender.

The bodies of eight skiers were found near **Lake Tahoe** in California after the area was buried by an **avalanche** on Tuesday—the deadliest in America since 1981. Six other members of the backcountry skiing group were rescued earlier; one remains missing and is presumed dead. Local officials said rescuers have not recovered the bodies because of the risk of another avalanche.

The online marketplace **eBay**, a destination for bargain-hunters, struck a cut-price deal of its own. The company will buy **Depop**, a resale app that is popular among Gen Z, for $1.2bn; Etsy, another digital marketplace, bought it for $1.6bn in 2021. Etsy's boss said the deal will allow it to invest in growing its own platform.

French prosecutors started two inquiries into alleged human and financial crimes linked to **Jeffrey Epstein**, a dead sex offender, following the release of fresh documents. Five magistrates will examine the Epstein files to assess whether any French nationals are implicated. Authorities said they hoped that renewed scrutiny will prompt victims to come forward. An earlier French probe was closed in 2023.

Figure of the day: 5–9%, the expected decline in China's car sales this year. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

America’s new pay-to-play diplomacy

Donald Trump will host the inaugural meeting of his “Board of Peace” in Washington, DC on Thursday. The United Nations has endorsed the board as the mechanism for ending the war in Gaza and overseeing its reconstruction. But Mr Trump’s ambitions seem more expansive: he claims a remit for the board “far beyond Gaza” and admits it may supplant the cash-starved UN.

Membership to the board, like a private club, is by invitation. Governments can buy permanent seats for $1bn and Mr Trump is chairman for life. American officials say those planning to attend on Thursday include Israel, Turkey, Gulf Arab monarchies and, more warily, India as well as several European and Asian allies. But many others have declined.

The board argues that it can “depart from approaches and institutions that have too often failed”; Mr Trump says he has raised $5bn for Gazans. The board’s success will not be measured by the show in Washington, but by what it achieves in Gaza.

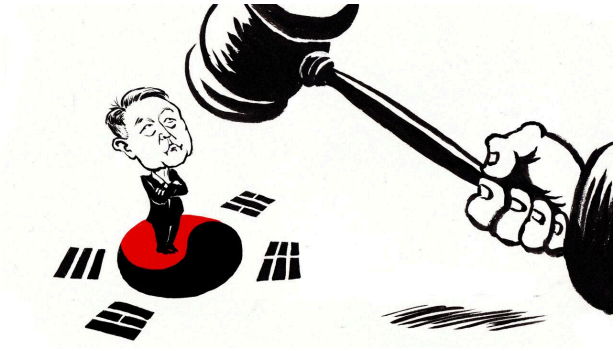


Illustration: David Simonds

Yoon Suk Yeol found guilty of leading an insurrection

In December 2024 Yoon Suk Yeol, then South Korea's president, declared martial law, accusing members of the National Assembly of exposing the country to "anti-state" forces. The legislature quickly ousted him. On Thursday judges found him guilty of leading an insurrection and sentenced him to life imprisonment. Prosecutors had sought the death penalty. He is expected to appeal.

Mr Yoon, who is 65, has already received a five-year prison sentence for blocking his arrest and is the defendant in seven other trials. The Democratic Party, which has a parliamentary majority, wants to pass an amendment that would prevent any government from pardoning him. Mr Yoon's People Power Party has yet to condemn his actions; another guilty verdict would plunge it further into crisis.

Photograph: EPA

The limits of India’s AI dream

On Thursday Narendra Modi, India’s prime minister, will address politicians and tech executives gathered in Delhi for the fourth “AI Impact Summit”—and the first to be held in a developing country. Since the annual conference began in Britain in 2023 as a forum for earnest discussion of artificial intelligence’s risks, it has morphed into something closer to a global trade fair.

Hoping to capture some of that buzz, India is casting itself as an emerging AI superpower. Such talk is mostly hot air: the country struggles to produce the advanced semiconductors AI needs and, despite a recent boom in data centres, lacks adequate computing power. Yet it has advantages: namely 900m internet users who spend an average of seven hours a day online, a huge source of data which can be used to train models. And Indian firms are adopting AI at a faster rate than the rest of the world. What it can definitely supply is demand.

Photograph: Getty Images

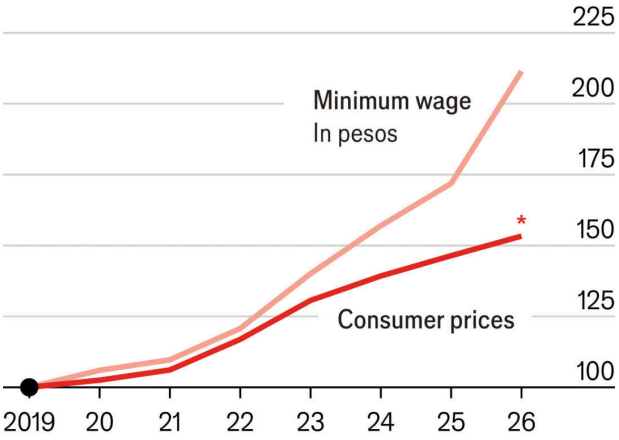
Rage over Colombia’s minimum wage

On Thursday Colombians will take to the streets in support of the new minimum wage. Last week, a court suspended a decree from Gustavo Petro, Colombia’s left-wing president, to raise the minimum wage by almost 24%. Workers have welcomed the increase. But critics argue that it will push up inflation and lead to job cuts. The court deemed it economically “unjustified”, and has given the government until Friday to suggest an alternative that complies with the law.

The clash is the latest between Mr Petro and Colombia’s institutions. When his tax reform bill was rejected by Congress last year he tried to impose tax increases by emergency decree; the courts suspended that, too. He has blamed these setbacks on an “institutional blockade”. Colombia holds primaries and legislative elections in March—and Mr Petro may be hoping that his fighting with the courts will distract voters from other problems, such as security, healthcare and corruption.

Peso-mism

Colombia, 2019=100



Sources: Bloomberg; Haver Analytics; IMF *Forecast

Photograph: Reuters

Can London Fashion Week reclaim its crown?

In the “Cool Britannia” era of the early 2000s, London was a fashion powerhouse. London Fashion Week, which starts on Thursday, was the highlight of the industry’s calendar, thanks to local designers like Stella McCartney and Alexander McQueen. But labels from Milan and Paris have since stolen much of that shine, and higher trade costs after Brexit have battered Britain’s fashion industry.

Laura Weir, the new head of the British Fashion Council, the trade body behind LFW, might change things. She has attracted new foreign buyers and press, and secured an extension of a government fund for emerging talent. And she has scrapped the five-figure fee to appear on the main runway, something that had priced out smaller designers. Ms Weir says she wants to lure back brands like McQueen—which showed its latest designs in Paris this year. The Fashion Council claims the industry contributed 3% of Britain’s GDP. With the right makeover, London’s runways could regain some of their swagger.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which Canadian business, originally founded in 1670 and noted for its department stores, was finally liquidated in 2025?

Wednesday: Which famous drummer was one of the founder members of the rock group Cream?

The one thing that doesn’t abide by majority rule is a person’s conscience.

Harper Lee